



A PRACTICAL INDIA-FIRST LAUNCH SYSTEM

DROPSHIPPING BUSINESS BLUEPRINT

Find a viable product. Verify the supplier. Know your margins. Launch a store you can actually operate.

30-DAY ACTION PLAN • WORKSHEETS • SCRIPTS • CHECKLISTS

NAVIGATION

Contents

Follow the sequence once; return to the worksheets whenever you test a new product or supplier.

PHASE	PAGES	WHAT YOU WILL BUILD
Understand the model	4-5	Order flow, route choice and product screen.
Verify the opportunity	6-9	Demand evidence, supplier scorecard and sample test.
Make the numbers work	10-11	Contribution margin and compliance questions.
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Launch responsibly	15-19	Traffic, creative, operations, support and dashboard.
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Use the working pages	22-25	Launch brief, supplier sheet, economics and checklist.
Verify and continue	26-27	Sources, further reading and next action.

REFERENCE KEY

Verified external information is tied to the primary sources on page 26. Recommendations are LEARNORA operating guidance. Illustrative Examples are hypothetical teaching scenarios and are labelled where used.

START HERE

A business, not a shortcut

Use this guide to build a small, testable retail operation with clear ownership of the customer experience.

The five decisions you will make

DECISION	YOUR OUTPUT
Customer and problem	One specific buyer and one purchase situation.
Product and supplier	A shortlist, a sample order and a written operating agreement.
Economics	A contribution margin and break-even acquisition ceiling.
Store and offer	A truthful product page, checkout and clear policies.
Launch and learning	A controlled test, an order log and a stop/iterate rule.

REALITY CHECK

Dropshipping removes the need to hold inventory before sale. It does not remove the cost of samples, marketing, support, refunds, tax compliance or supplier errors. You can lose money even when orders arrive.

How to use the book

- Read pages 3-10 before paying for a store or an ad.
- Copy the worksheets and fill them with real supplier quotes.
- Treat all rupee amounts marked Illustrative Example as arithmetic practice, not market prices or earnings forecasts.

01 / THE MODEL

What actually happens

The supplier holds stock and dispatches the item. Your store wins the sale and remains the customer-facing business.

Order flow

STEP	OWNER	PROOF TO KEEP
1. Customer pays your store	You	Order number and payment record
2. You transmit the order	You	Supplier order ID and address confirmation
3. Supplier packs and ships	Supplier	Dispatch time, carrier and tracking
4. Customer receives or returns	You + supplier	Delivery proof and return outcome

Choose a route deliberately

ROUTE	BEST FIRST USE	WATCH OUT FOR
Domestic supplier + own store	Control the offer and support with shorter logistics chain.	Supplier stock accuracy, packaging, returns and cash flow.
Marketplace	Demand may exist on the platform.	Seller policies and fees; do not assume any fulfilment method is permitted.
Cross-border sourcing	Only after product and operations are proven.	Import, customs, duties, lead time and customer expectations.

WORKING PRINCIPLE

Start with one market, one product family and one fulfilment path. Avoid promising dispatch or delivery dates until you have tested them end to end.

02 / PRODUCT SELECTION

Choose a problem to solve

A good starter product is understandable, demonstrable and feasible to fulfil consistently.

A practical product screen

CHECK	GREEN SIGNAL	RED FLAG
Buyer need	A clear job or recurring irritation	Novelty with no convincing use
Demonstration	Benefit visible in a short demo	Needs exaggerated results
Shipping	Compact, resilient, easy to pack	Fragile, bulky or high damage exposure
Support	Simple use and few compatibility issues	Sizing, safety or technical ambiguity
Supply	Sample available and stock can be checked	No sample or shifting specifications

Avoid beginning with categories that need complex approvals, safety claims or specialist support, such as ingestibles, medical devices, cosmetics with claims, branded replicas and certain electronics. Verify category-specific rules before listing any regulated item.

EXERCISE

Write: “For [specific buyer] who [specific situation], this [product] helps [observable outcome] by [mechanism].” If you need vague claims to complete the sentence, reconsider the product.

03 / DEMAND VALIDATION

Find evidence before inventory

Search interest is a clue; completed purchases and customer language matter more than a viral video.

The evidence ladder

EVIDENCE	HOW TO COLLECT	WHAT TO RECORD
Search intent	Search marketplaces and Google for the exact problem and product.	Variants, price bands, complaints and questions.
Competing listings	Read low-star and recent reviews; avoid copying claims.	Patterns in fit, quality, shipping and use.
Buyer conversations	Ask 5-10 target buyers how they solve the problem today.	Exact phrases, alternatives and objections.
Small offer test	Show a truthful landing page or organic post to relevant people.	Visits, inquiries, cart actions and actual purchases.

Interview prompt

COPY-PASTE

"I am researching [problem]. What do you currently use? What is frustrating about it? When did you last buy a solution? What would make you trust a new store?" Do not pitch until the person has answered.

Decision rule: continue only when you can name a clear buyer, show a real problem, locate a testable supplier and explain why your offer is better than a readily available alternative.

04 / SUPPLIER DILIGENCE

Treat the supplier as a partner

The cheapest quote is rarely the only number that matters.

Supplier scorecard — rate 1 to 5 with evidence

DIMENSION	ASK / TEST	SCORE
Product consistency	Same SKU/specification across two sample orders?	___ / 5
Stock visibility	How often is stock confirmed and how are stockouts reported?	___ / 5
Dispatch reliability	Cutoff time, typical handover and exception process?	___ / 5
Packaging	Whose branding appears? What is included in the parcel?	___ / 5
Returns	Who authorises, receives and pays for each return scenario?	___ / 5
Documentation	Business identity, invoice, applicable product documents?	___ / 5

Keep notes, quotes and screenshots. Compare two or three suppliers for the same product. A supplier should answer operational questions in writing before you advertise.

NON-NEGOTIABLE

Order a sample to a normal customer address. Inspect the product, packaging, invoice or slip, tracking updates and actual delivery time. Repeat when the SKU or supplier changes.

05 / SUPPLIER OUTREACH

Questions that prevent disputes

Send these before agreeing to list a product. Keep the final terms in a shared document or contract.

Copy-paste supplier message

MESSAGE

"Hello, I run an online retail store serving customers in India. I am evaluating [SKU]. Please share a sample ordering process, unit price by quantity, packing and shipping charges by serviceable PIN code, stock update method, dispatch cutoff, tracking timeline, damage/defect policy, return address, settlement terms, invoice/branding options and any product compliance documents. Can we run a paid test order first?"

Put responsibility in writing

EVENT	AGREE WHO DOES WHAT
Wrong item or defect	Evidence required; replacement/refund payer; response deadline.
Carrier delay or loss	Escalation owner, tracking updates, claim evidence.
Customer cancellation	Cutoff before dispatch and handling after handover.
Return to origin / COD refusal	Reverse freight, inspection and reattempt decision.
Data and branding	Permitted use of customer details and documents in parcel.

06 / THE SAMPLE TEST

Test like a customer

Run the entire buying journey before accepting a real order.

Sample order inspection sheet

CHECK	RECORD
Listing vs actual product	Dimensions, material, colour, functionality and visible defects.
Transit	Order date, dispatch timestamp, scans and delivery date.
Parcel	Protection, damage, price tag, invoice and seller identity.
Usability	Follow directions; take original photos and a short demonstration.
Support	Ask a routine question; record response quality and time.
Returns trial	Confirm address, eligibility, inspection and refund process.

PASS / FIX / REJECT

PASS if the product matches the listing and the fulfilment promise is repeatable. FIX if the gap has a documented owner and retest date. REJECT if quality, provenance, safety or supplier responsiveness remains uncertain.

Do not use supplier photos without permission. Do not show a feature or result the sample cannot demonstrate. Keep the sample for comparison if later customer complaints appear.

07 / UNIT ECONOMICS

Do the maths before ads

Revenue is not profit. Work out contribution per delivered order with actual quotes and realistic loss allowances.

Illustrative Example — replace every input

LINE ITEM	AMOUNT
Customer price, excluding any tax you must remit	₹999
Product paid to supplier	– ₹420
Forward shipping and packing	– ₹85
Payment and platform transaction cost	– ₹25
Expected refund / RTO allowance per order	– ₹80
Contribution before acquisition and fixed costs	₹389

In this Illustrative Example, spending ₹250 to acquire one delivered order leaves ₹139 before fixed store costs, overhead and taxes. If acquisition costs ₹450, the contribution becomes negative ₹61. These figures are hypothetical, not a recommended selling price, fee schedule or expected result.

Your working formulas

COPY INTO A SHEET

Contribution before ads = collected revenue – product – shipping/packing – transaction costs – expected refunds and return-to-origin losses – other variable costs. Maximum break-even acquisition cost = contribution before ads. Target acquisition cost should leave room for overhead and profit.

For COD, separately model refusal, remittance timing and return-to-origin charges. Ask an accountant how GST applies to your exact invoice chain; do not treat tax collected from a customer as profit.

08 / RISK AND COMPLIANCE

Get the basics right

This page is general education for Indian sellers. Rules depend on the product, location, selling channel and transaction structure.

Before taking payments

- Check whether your business needs GST registration, and how invoices, interstate supply and marketplace transactions apply to your model. Use current GST portal and CBIC guidance or a qualified accountant.
- Show accurate product, price, delivery, return, refund and contact information. Keep a process to resolve customer complaints. Consult the Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) Rules, 2020.
- For imported goods, check product restrictions, customs, labelling, duties and whether an Importer-Exporter Code is needed for your role; seek specialist advice before promising delivery.
- Check product-specific approvals, advertising claims, intellectual property and packaging declarations before listing. Do not sell counterfeit goods or invent certifications.

MARKETPLACE CAUTION

Amazon India allows certain third-party fulfilment only under its dropshipping policy, including seller-of-record requirements and responsibility for returns. Check the live policy of every marketplace you use; an own-store arrangement does not automatically meet marketplace rules.

09 / STORE STACK

Build only what the buyer needs

A working store is a clear offer, functional checkout and reliable order handling, not a large catalogue.

Minimum viable stack

JOB	PRACTICAL OPTION	VERIFY BEFORE LAUNCH
Storefront	Hosted commerce platform or a maintained WooCommerce setup.	Mobile speed, tax settings, checkout and support links.
Payments	Indian payment gateway with supported methods such as UPI/cards.	Eligibility, fees, settlement, refund workflow.
Order tracker	Store admin + simple order sheet while volume is small.	Order ID, supplier ID, status, customer updates.
Creative	Your own product photos/video and editable graphics.	Permissions and claim accuracy.
Measurement	Platform analytics and tagged links.	Purchases, source and refunded orders.

Shopify and WooCommerce are implementation examples, not endorsements. Compare current pricing, tax features and integrations on their official sites before paying. Payment method availability depends on gateway setup and merchant eligibility.

TEST TRANSACTION

Place a legitimate low-value test order or use the gateway test mode, then check order confirmation, payment status, supplier handoff, shipping notifications and the refund flow. Disable test mode before live sales.

10 / PRODUCT PAGE

Answer the buyer's doubts

Your product page should help someone decide without a sales call.

Page blueprint

BLOCK	WHAT TO WRITE OR SHOW
Headline	Plain product name + specific use; avoid "miracle" claims.
First visual	Actual product in context, with scale where useful.
Three benefits	Explain the feature, use situation and limit honestly.
Specifications	Materials, size, compatibility, care, contents and origin as applicable.
Fulfilment	Serviceable locations, expected dispatch and delivery estimate.
Trust	Contact details, payment methods, refund and return links.
FAQ	Fit, assembly, warranty and the most common objection.

Illustrative Example: desk organiser

BEFORE / AFTER

Weak: "Best desk organiser ever! Limited stock!"

Better: "Compact desk organiser for chargers, pens and small daily items. View the measured dimensions, included parts and available colours before ordering."

Never copy competitor photos or reviews. Do not manufacture urgency, display unverified discount anchors or suggest customer testimonials that do not exist.

11 / OFFER DESIGN

Make the choice easy

An offer connects a clear buyer outcome with a fair price and a delivery promise you can meet.

Offer canvas

QUESTION	FILL IN
Who is it for?	For _____
What is included?	Product / variant / quantity / support: _____
What does it cost?	Displayed price and applicable shipping: ₹ _____
When does it arrive?	Estimated dispatch: _____ delivery: _____
What if it is wrong?	Return/refund route: _____
Why trust this store?	Real sample visuals and reachable support: _____

PRICE DECISION

Use the unit economics sheet to determine a sustainable price. Compare the delivered value with visible alternatives. A lower price can create a worse business if refunds, shipping or support are underfunded.

Start with a simple single-product offer or a coherent small collection. Add bundles only when the items genuinely work together and the supplier can pack them reliably.

12 / FIRST TRAFFIC

Prove the message before scaling

Choose one primary channel that matches how your buyer discovers and evaluates the product.

Channel choice

CHANNEL	WHEN IT FITS	FIRST EXPERIMENT
Short-form organic	Demonstrable visual benefit.	Film three use cases from your actual sample.
Search content	Buyer searches the problem or product.	Publish a useful comparison or FAQ page.
Paid social	You can fund testing and track delivered-order economics.	One audience hypothesis, two distinct creatives.
Creator collaboration	A relevant audience can show real use.	Brief one creator; agree on disclosure and rights.

Set a loss limit before an ad test. Measure purchases and delivered contribution, not only clicks or messages. Pause a test if the product cannot fulfil or the economics cannot support acquisition.

LEARNING LOG

For each experiment, record: hypothesis • audience • creative angle • spend or effort • visits • add-to-carts • orders • delivered orders • refunds • contribution • next decision.

13 / CREATIVE SYSTEM

Show, explain, prove

A useful ad demonstrates the product without hiding limitations.

Three honest creative angles

ANGLE	SHOT LIST	SAMPLE OPENING
Problem to use	Mess/problem → product in use → close-up.	"Here is how I organise my everyday cables."
How it works	Unbox → show dimensions → demonstrate steps.	"What actually comes in the box?"
Comparison	Show old routine beside new routine.	"A simpler setup for a small desk."

30-second video outline

- 0–3 seconds: name the buyer situation and show the real object.
- 3–18 seconds: demonstrate one or two use steps; label dimensions or limitations where relevant.
- 18–25 seconds: show what is included and how delivery/returns work.
- 25–30 seconds: invite the viewer to read the product page or ask a question.

COPY CHECK

Every claim should be observable or substantiated. Use only licensed music, permitted supplier material and genuine reviews. Check each advertising platform's current policies before publishing.

14 / OPERATIONS

The first ten orders are a systems test

Write the fulfilment routine before an order arrives.

Daily operating rhythm

WHEN	ACTION	EXCEPTION
New paid order	Verify address, variant, payment and stock; send to supplier.	If out of stock, offer an honest choice promptly.
Supplier acceptance	Capture supplier order ID and expected handover.	Escalate missed cutoff; update customer.
Dispatch	Check carrier/tracking; send accurate update.	Investigate missing or invalid tracking.
Delivery / return	Confirm outcome; log issue and cost.	Own the complaint even if supplier caused it.

Order log fields

SPREADSHEET HEADER

Date | Store order ID | SKU | Sale value | Payment type | Supplier ID | Supplier cost | Dispatch due | Tracking | Delivery status | Support issue | Refund/RTO cost | Contribution | Owner | Next action

Keep customer personal data only where necessary, limit access and follow your store's privacy commitments. Reconcile gateway settlements and supplier invoices regularly.

15 / CUSTOMER SUPPORT

A fast, honest update builds trust

Use these as starting scripts. Replace placeholders with facts from the actual order.

Copy-paste messages

Order received “Thanks for ordering [item]. Your order number is [ID]. We are confirming stock and will send an update by [time/date]. You can reach us at [channel].”

Dispatch delayed “Your [item] has not shipped on the original schedule. The current update is [verified fact]. We will update you again by [time/date]. If you prefer to cancel, please reply here and we will explain the available options.”

Damaged or wrong item “I am sorry this arrived in that condition. Please share photos of the item and outer package plus your order number. We will review and tell you the next step by [time/date] under our policy.”

Refund update “Your refund for order [ID] was initiated on [date] using [method]. The final posting time depends on the payment provider or bank. Here is the reference [ID]. Contact us if it has not appeared after the stated period.”

SERVICE RULE

Never promise a refund, replacement or delivery date before checking your actual policy and status. Give one clear next-update time and follow through.

16 / DECISION DASHBOARD

Measure the business that exists

Use a weekly review. Separate ordered, shipped, delivered and refunded orders.

Starter scorecard

METRIC	CALCULATION	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Checkout conversion	Orders ÷ qualified store visits	Page/offer friction; interpret with traffic quality.
Delivered-order share	Delivered orders ÷ placed orders	Fulfilment and COD quality.
Return/RTO share	Returned or RTO orders ÷ placed orders	Product, expectations or address issues.
Contribution per delivered order	Net collected sales less variable costs	Room for ads and overhead.
Support load	Issue tickets ÷ delivered orders	Hidden operational cost.

These are definitions for your internal dashboard, not industry benchmarks. Use a short notes column for causes; very small samples can swing heavily from one order.

WEEKLY DECISIONS

KEEP if product quality and contribution hold. FIX one bottleneck when the cause is identifiable. STOP if defects, unsupported claims, unsafe products or repeated negative contribution persist after a fair test.

17 / THE FIRST MONTH

30-day action plan · days 1-15

The goal is a measured launch, not a promised number of sales.

DAYS	FOCUS	DELIVERABLE / GATE
1-3	Select buyer and three product ideas.	One-page buyer/problem brief and product screen.
4-5	Study alternatives and buyer language.	Competitor/review notes; five buyer conversations if possible.
6-8	Contact at least two suppliers per shortlisted SKU.	Quotes, written answers and scorecard.
9-11	Order sample(s) and draft unit economics.	Sample order log; economics sheet with real quotes.
12-13	Inspect product and delivery; choose or reject.	Sample photos and pass/fix/reject decision.
14-15	Set up business, tax and policy questions.	List of professional or official confirmations needed.

GATE AT DAY 15

Proceed only when the sample and supplier pass, basic economics are plausible, and you understand the legal and operational questions for your selling route. Otherwise use the rest of the month to correct those gaps.

18 / THE FIRST MONTH

30-day action plan · days 16–30

A small controlled test produces better information than a rushed large launch.

DAYS	FOCUS	DELIVERABLE / GATE
16–18	Build product page and policies.	Actual sample visuals, delivery estimate, FAQ and contact.
19–20	Configure payment, tracking and order workflow.	End-to-end checkout and supplier handoff test.
21–23	Make three truthful content pieces.	Product demo, use case and FAQ creative.
24–26	Run one channel test within a chosen loss limit.	Daily learning log and customer questions.
27–28	Review orders and service issues.	Delivered contribution and issue causes.
29–30	Choose next cycle.	Keep, revise or stop; one improvement to test next.

After day 30

If the product works, improve one variable at a time: listing clarity, supplier consistency, conversion or acquisition. If it does not, retain the evidence and return to product selection. Do not scale spend to compensate for unresolved fulfilment.

19 / WORKBOOK

One-page launch brief

Fill this out before spending on traffic. Blank lines are intentional working space.

FIELD	YOUR ANSWER
Buyer and buying situation	_____
Main problem and existing alternatives	_____
Proposed product / SKU	_____
Top two suppliers and sample dates	_____
Observed delivery time / packaging	_____
Sale price and contribution before ads	_____
Maximum test loss and traffic channel	_____
Refund / return owner and process	_____
First experiment and success condition	_____

REVIEW

What evidence would make you stop this product? Write it before launch:

20 / WORKBOOK

Supplier comparison sheet

Compare actual samples, not only catalogue photos or quoted prices.

CRITERION	SUPPLIER A	SUPPLIER B
Product / SKU	_____	_____
Landed unit cost	_____	_____
Sample received?	_____	_____
Quality observations	_____	_____
Dispatch promise	_____	_____
Actual sample delivery	_____	_____
Packaging / invoice	_____	_____
Return / defect terms	_____	_____
Stock update method	_____	_____
Biggest uncertainty	_____	_____

Decision: choose [A / B / neither] because _____.

Next verification: _____.

21 / WORKBOOK

Economics worksheet

Use one sheet per SKU and shipping zone. Separate prepaid and COD if their costs differ.

INPUT	AMOUNT / ASSUMPTION
Displayed price and shipping collected	₹ _____
GST or other tax treatment (confirm professionally)	_____
Supplier product + packing	₹ _____
Forward shipping	₹ _____
Payment / marketplace fees	₹ _____
Expected return, refund and RTO allowance	₹ _____
Other variable cost	₹ _____
Contribution before acquisition	₹ _____
Planned acquisition cost per delivered order	₹ _____
Contribution after acquisition	₹ _____

SENSITIVITY TEST

Recalculate if supplier cost rises, delivery is delayed or returns increase. Can you still support customers and pay overhead? If not, revise the offer or stop.

22 / QUICK REFERENCE

Launch checklist

A short operational gate you can revisit when adding another product.

Product and supplier

- ☐ Specific buyer and problem identified; alternative products reviewed.
- ☐ Physical sample tested; listing matches product; images are permitted.
- ☐ Stock, dispatch, packaging, defects, returns and data handling agreed in writing.

Store and compliance

- ☐ Product details, total cost, contact, delivery and return information are clear.
- ☐ Applicable GST, invoicing, import and product rules checked for this model.
- ☐ Checkout, confirmation, payment and refund flow tested end to end.

Launch and support

- ☐ Unit economics include shipping, fees and plausible loss allowance.
- ☐ Order log, tracking owner, support scripts and escalation path are ready.
- ☐ Test channel, measurement, loss limit and stop criteria recorded.

23 / SOURCES

Sources & further reading

Official and primary references checked for this edition in September 2026. Policies and product features can change.

Shopify, “What Is Dropshipping and How Does It Work?”

<https://www.shopify.com/blog/what-is-dropshipping>

Shopify, “Dropshipping Fulfillment: The Complete Guide”

<https://www.shopify.com/blog/dropshipping-fulfillment>

Department of Consumer Affairs, Consumer Protection (E-Commerce) Rules, 2020

<https://consumeraffairs.nic.in/acts-and-rules/consumer-protection/consumer-protection>

CBIC, GST sectoral FAQs (verify latest notifications with the GST portal)

<https://cbic-gst.gov.in/sectoral-faq.html>

GST Portal, taxpayer guidance and registration resources

<https://www.gst.gov.in/>

DGFT, Foreign Trade Policy and IEC resources

<https://www.dgft.gov.in/CP/>

Amazon Seller Central India, Drop Shipping Policy

<https://sellercentral.amazon.in/gp/help/external/G201808410>

Razorpay, Shopify payment gateway troubleshooting and FAQ

<https://razorpay.com/docs/payments/payment-gateway/ecommerce-plugins/shopify/faqs/>

EDITORIAL NOTE

Examples, prompts, scoring systems and templates in this guide are LEARNORA teaching tools. The rupee calculation is explicitly illustrative. For tax, legal and product compliance decisions, consult current official material and a qualified professional.

LEARNORA

BUILD A SMALL BUSINESS YOU CAN OPERATE.

Your next move: complete the launch brief, request two supplier quotes and place one test order. Let verified evidence determine the next step.

Learn today. Earn tomorrow.